Name:	Date:

Read the selection and choose the best answer to each question.

from Shakuntala

by Kālidāsa

The poet and playwright Kālidāsa likely lived before 500 CE in what is now India. His plays, including Shakuntala*, are considered the finest surviving examples of classical Sanskrit literature. In the excerpts that follow, a young woman named Shakuntala, who was abandoned at birth and raised by a hermit, meets King Dushyanta while the king is on a hunting trip. He falls in love and marries Shakuntala, but a curse causes him to lose his memory of her. In the excerpt from Act IV, Shakuntala prepares to leave the grove where she was raised to seek out her husband at the royal court. In the excerpt from Act V, she arrives at court.*

Characters

KANVA: a hermit and a wise man

GAUTAMI: Kanva's wife and a wise woman

SHAKUNTALA: a young woman raised by Kanva and Gautami

SHARNGARAVA: a student of Kanva

SHARADVATA: a student of Kanva

PRIYAMVADA: a friend of Shakuntala

KING DUSHYANTA: the monarch

CHAMBERLAIN: an official in the King's court

PORTRESS: a servant of the King

from Act IV: "Shakuntala's Departure"

1 **KANVA:** Shakuntala must go to-day;
I miss her now at heart;
I dare not speak a loving word
Or choking tears will start.

My eyes are dim with anxious thought;
Love strikes me to the life:
And yet I strove for pious peace—
I have no child, no wife.

What must a father feel, when come
The pangs of parting from his child at home?

[*He walks about the two friends.*] There, Shakuntala, we have arranged your ornaments.[1] Now put on this beautiful silk dress. [*SHAKUNTALA rises and does so.*]

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2 **GAUTAMI:** My child, here is your father. The eyes with which he seems to embrace you are overflowing with tears of joy. You must greet him properly. [*SHAKUNTALA makes a shamefaced reverence.*]

3 [*Kanva and Shakuntala take part in a brief spiritual ceremony.*]

4 **KANVA:** Now you may start, my daughter. [*He glances about.*] Where are Sharngarava and Sharadvata? [*Enter the two pupils.*]

5 **SHARNGARAVA and SHARADVATA:** We are here, Father.

6 **KANVA:** Sharngarava, my son, lead the way for your sister.

7 **SHARNGARAVA:** Follow me. [*They all walk about.*]

8 **KANVA:** O trees of the pious grove, in which the fairies dwell,

She would not drink till she had wet
Your roots, a sister's duty,
Nor pluck your flowers; she loves you yet
Far more than selfish beauty.

'Twas festival in her pure life
When budding blossoms showed;
And now she leaves you as a wife—
Oh, speed her on her road!

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1. ornaments jewelry

9 **SHARNGARAVA:** [*listening to the song of koïl-birds*] Father,

The trees are answering your prayer
In cooing cuckoo-song,
Bidding Shakuntala farewell,
Their sister for so long.

Invisible beings,

May lily-dotted lakes delight your eye;
May shade-trees bid the heat of noonday cease;
May soft winds blow the lotus-pollen nigh;
May all your path be pleasantness and peace.

10 [*All listen in astonishment.*]

11 **GAUTAMI:** My child, the fairies of the pious grove bid you farewell. For they love the household. Pay reverence to the holy ones.

12 **SHAKUNTALA:** [*does so. Aside to PRIYAMVADA*] Priyamvada, I long to see my husband, and yet my feet will hardly move. It is hard, hard to leave the hermitage.

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13 **PRIYAMVADA:** You are not the only one to feel sad at this farewell. See how the whole grove feels at parting from you.

The grass drops from the feeding doe;
The peahen stops her dance;
Pale, trembling leaves are falling slow,
The tears of clinging plants.

14 [*Shakuntala bids farewell to the plants and animals of the grove. Kanva promises to care for them in her absence and asks Shakuntala to tell the King that he, Kanva, reminds the King of his religious duty to honor and respect Shakuntala as his wife. Kanva also gives Shakuntala advice about how best to act in the King's household, suggesting she be kind and faithful. Shakuntala reluctantly departs, and Kanva expresses his sorrow at her leaving.*]

from Act V: "Shakuntala's Rejection"

15 [*King Dushyanta relaxes at court. He listens to a song about lost love.*]

16 **KING**: [*to himself*] Why am I filled with wistfulness on hearing such a song? I am not separated from one I love. And yet

In face of sweet presentment
Or harmonies of sound,
Man e'er forgets contentment,
By wistful longings bound.

There must be recollections
Of things not seen on earth,
Deep nature's predilections,[2]
Loves earlier than birth.

17 [*He shows the wistfulness that comes from unremembered things.*]

18 **CHAMBERLAIN:** *[approaching]* Victory to your Majesty. Here are hermits who dwell in the forest at the foot of the Himalayas. They bring women with them, and they carry a message from Kanva.

19 [*The King, Chamberlain, and other officials go to a sanctuary where they receive Shakuntala's party.*]

20 **KING:** [*observing SHAKUNTALA*] Ah!

Who is she, shrouded in the veil
That dims her beauty's lustre,
Among the hermits like a flower
Round which the dead leaves cluster?

21 **PORTRESS:** Your Majesty, she is well worth looking at.

22 **KING:** Enough! I must not gaze upon another's wife.

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23 **SHAKUNTALA:** [*laying her hand on her breast. Aside*] Oh, my heart, why tremble so? Remember his constant love and be brave.

24 [*The group delivers Kanva's message to the King, which gives his permission for the wedding that has already taken place. The King, surprised, rejects the message.*]

25 **GAUTAMI:** [*to SHAKUNTALA*] Forget your shame, my child. I will remove your veil. Then your husband will recognise you. [*She does so.*]

26 **KING**: [*observing SHAKUNTALA. To himself*]

As my heart ponders whether I could ever
Have wed this woman that has come to me
In tortured loveliness, as I endeavour
To bring it back to mind, then like a bee

That hovers round a jasmine flower at dawn,
While frosty dews of morning still o'erweave it,
And hesitates to sip ere they be gone,
I cannot taste the sweet, and cannot leave it. . . .

27 **SHARNGARAVA:** Have you nothing to say, O King?

28 **KING:** Hermit, I have taken thought. I cannot believe that this woman is my wife.

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2. predilections preferences; things favored most

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16. Which of these phrases **best** explains the meaning of the word *wistfulness* in paragraph 16 of Act V?

A longing or melancholy

B anxiety or nervousness

C outrage or condemnation

D disappointment or frustration

17. Read these lines from paragraph 1 of the play.

> What must a father feel, when come
> The pangs of parting from his child at home?

Which of the following statements describes the effect of the figurative language in these lines?

A The consonance (*what/when* and *come/child*) emphasizes words that create a mood of surprise and thankfulness.

B The consonance (*what/when* and *come/child*) emphasizes words that create a mood of loss and confusion.

C The alliteration (*father/feel* and *pangs/parting*) emphasizes words that create a mood of sadness and longing.

D The alliteration (*father/feel* and *pangs/parting*) emphasizes words that create a mood of joy and pride.

18. What is the **main** purpose of the scene in paragraph 26?

A to reveal the King's thoughts about his role in the natural world

B to foreshadow the nature of the King's future relationship with Shakuntala

C to show that the King wants to remember because he finds Shakuntala so attractive

to explain why the King rejects Kanva's message and refuses to speak to the group

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19. Read these lines, which form paragraph 12 of the play.

SHAKUNTALA: [*does so. Aside to PRIYAMVADA*] Priyamvada, I long to see my husband, and yet my feet will hardly move. It is hard, hard to leave the hermitage.

What is the **primary** function of this aside?

A It reveals Shakuntala's internal struggle.

B It makes the reader feel pity for Priyamvada.

C It shows how close Shakuntala is to Priyamvada.

D It suggests future problems in Shakuntala's marriage.

20. The following question has two parts. Answer Part A first, and then Part B.

Part A Which statement **best** describes the conflict Shakuntala confronts in Act IV?

A Shakuntala confronts the king's changed feelings about her.

B Shakuntala confronts the unequal treatment of women in her culture.

C Shakuntala struggles with leaving her home and family to reunite with the king.

D Shakuntala struggles with deciding whether to marry the king or stay with her father.

Part B Which statement **best** describes how the conflict identified in Part A changes Shakuntala?

A Shakuntala learns to challenge cultural norms.

B Shakuntala asserts her independence from the king.

C Shakuntala recognizes the importance of family and stays home.

D Shakuntala decides that she must follow her heart and rejoin the king.

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21. Read paragraph 16 of *Shakuntala*. How does the predominant *abab* rhyme scheme affect the play?

A The simple *abab* rhyme scheme creates a playful pattern that undercuts the sense of sadness.

B The steady *abab* rhyme scheme lends a formal dignity to characters' thoughts and feelings.

C The fast-paced *abab* rhyme scheme lets the audience know that something is about to happen.

D The musical *abab* rhyme scheme indicates when a character has switched from dialogue to song.

22. Read these lines from an adaptation of the play.

> Sharon walked in the garden with her father. He pointed out the flowers on the trees that would become apples, and the seeds of the grasses blowing in the wind. It was hard to believe that Dad wanted her to leave and follow Jack. Jack was such a miserable, self-absorbed creature—always looking for new ways to expand his farm, new equipment to buy, and new deals to be struck. But Jack was her husband, after all, though he seemed to find it convenient to forget that he was married when it suited him. But maybe Dad knew something she didn't.

What conflict in the adaptation is similar to a conflict in the play?

A the conflict between good and evil

B the conflict between youth and age

C the conflict between people and nature

D the conflict between stasis and change

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